

own *mayajaal* has been hard at work.

Nothing about his cricket though ever was an illusion. The cricketer was more than substantial, all flesh, blood and palpable ambition, yet the stuff of dreams. He played like a king but belonged to the common man. He brought home cricket's ultimate prize and started a revolution. His career created the legend and the legend created the illusion—of the large-hearted, son of the soil—that Dev has strenuously kept alive and built upon more than a decade after retirement.

Listen to Ashish Kaul, executive vice-president, Essel Group and you understand the power of Dev's persona. "There is no greater legend than Kapil, he is the ideal example of courage under fire. He is enigmatic, yet simple. He lets his

spinning off from the 1983 World Cup win, three autobiographies and a TV chat show called *Dil Se*. For all his fiery rhetoric on TV about BCCI, Dev has done sustained business with them, be it floodlighting grounds or accepting positions. He quit as India coach as the heat around match-fixing grew and then turned up later, weeping on TV. He was never directly singled out for punishment. While shooting for his chat show with Mohammad Azharuddin in 2005,

has just joined another company which is into event management."

One of Dev's old adversaries met him after 10 years and said, "That is not the man I played against. Now, you can see the dollar signs in his eyes." But being focussed on money is a matter of predisposition, hardly a crime. An acquaintance known to Dev for more than two decades describes him better. "When he played, Kapil had *jazba* (emotion), you know, he really did, he wanted to win for India." After the cricket ended, says the associate, "He has not been involved with cricket in any constructive way. He will not create anything. He can take an emotional pitch on ICL now but his instinct has been that of a trader."

In late 2002, when the current players formed their association,



UNDER FIRE: Srinivasan

bility. BCCI had let go Rs 240 crore, which agitated officials say, would have cost any corporate executive his job. The allegation against Srinivasan is that his lapse enabled Zee to walk out of the contract without taking a financial hit. The money thus saved, goes the argument, could then be poured into the ICL launch.

BCCI Vice-President Shashank Manohar's explanation is different. Zee, he says, didn't owe the Board any money because the contract had been

terminated, brought to a close at the players' behest, who complained that the 'off-shore' games were meaningless. Encashing the guarantee would have meant claiming money that really didn't belong to them.

Srinivasan and Manohar are now ranged against Punjab Cricket Association President I.S. Bindra and BCCI Vice-President Lalit Modi. As the band of former allies splits, their old rival, former BCCI chief Jagmohan Dalmiya watches. Dalmiya denies meeting Zee Sports business head Himanshu Mody in Kolkata recently. He told INDIA TODAY, "As of now, I have no connection with the ICL," but added tantalisingly, "but nobody knows what will happen in the future."

traditional venues like Malaysia, Canada, Singapore for a sum of \$219.15 million for five years for a minimum of 25 matches.

In keeping with BCCI rules, Zee paid up a year's fee in advance. The Board's practice is to ask for a year's fee in advance and a bank guarantee to cover the following year of any contract. When the time came to pay up its second year's fee in advance, Zee dithered as it had seen a lukewarm response during the first year.

Rather than encash the guarantee of Rs 240 crore in hand, the Board's treasurer N. Srinivasan chose, or so the grapevine states, to go on a golfing holiday to Kodaikanal. The guarantee lapsed and Zee were able to walk out of the 'off-shore' contract with no lia-

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RAJU KULKARNI, FORMER INDIA FAST BOWLER

cricketing credentials speak for him." Perhaps because little else can.

Along with his cricket, Dev also built a successful business around coal, electrical components, flood lighting cricket stadia and a modest media company. He had a good life, played golf at the Delhi Golf Club and was a passionate punter on his own game. When the cricket market boomed after the 1996 World Cup, he ensured he stayed close to centrestage. There were countless endorsements

Dev was overheard telling him, "*Tu rota kyun nahin hai? Phir log tujhe sachcha samjhenge* (Why don't you cry? Then people will believe you)." Obviously, years of investment in image management have had invaluable returns.

Former India fast bowler Raju Kulkarni, once an overawed junior colleague says, "Kapil was a genius at work, completely cricket-oriented." Today, he is baffled by the fuss around the ICL and says, "The way I see it, Kapil

Dev, today the champion of players' rights, sneered. BCCI Vice-President Shashank Manohar says of Dev's now-truncated stint as chairman of the National Cricket Academy, "We offered him the highest position in the country to train youngsters, he had all the authority, all the freedom. We didn't interfere in whom he appointed, be it coach or trainer. What more did he want?"

Maybe something more Kapil Dev-centric—to keep the illusion going. ■